

Editorial Writing

District Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School. From the given information, write an **editorial** as you would for the high school newspaper.

Remember that as an editorial writer, you should **support or oppose** policy or action; you should not sermonize. You have **45 minutes**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 763 students enrolled in grades 9-12. Three weeks ago, the Leopard Lonestars dance team announced their three new captains and eight new lieutenants for the 2026-2027 school year. This year, 23 of the 50 underclassmen applied and tried out for a leadership position. Selected leaders were notified of the results via phone call.

As is tradition for the Lonestars, on the Saturday night following the announcement, current captains arranged with parents of new officers to enter their homes and surprise them, waking them up around 2 a.m. The captains told the students to get dressed and get into one student's SUV. The group had a series of early morning challenges planned as part of what they called an "initiation ceremony" for the new captains.

But on the way to the local church to complete the challenges, senior Sarah Ravitch, who was driving the SUV, swerved to miss an animal in the road, hit a parked car, and junior Mallory O'Brien was knocked out of the SUV, breaking her collarbone and sustaining multiple cuts and bruises. Two other students hit their heads and were diagnosed with concussions.

As a result of the incident, O'Brien's family is suing the school district and seeking restitution for medical bills and emotional damage. In addition, head dance coach Andrea Wyatt was placed on administrative leave with pay pending a hazing investigation, and all dance team leadership has been placed in the Disciplinary Alternative Education Program for 45 days. Also, the spring dance show scheduled for May 2 has been canceled.

After unsuccessful appeals to the principal and superintendent, a group of dance team members and their parents will attend the March 26 school board meeting and ask for the students' DAEP placement to be reduced. They will also ask for Wyatt's reinstatement. You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed March 24.

THOSE SUPPORTING THE TEAM'S APPEAL

The dance team leadership has been following this tradition for years. No one has ever gotten hurt. Parents are always aware of the event, and the activities scheduled are more like team-building games. This was not hazing. It was an accident. While Wyatt was aware of the tradition, she was not involved in the planning of the event. Further, the 45-day DAEP placement is extreme for an accident resulting from an innocent team-building event.

THOSE OPPOSING THE TEAM'S APPEAL

The district has to have a zero tolerance policy for hazing behavior. While the event occurred off campus outside the school day, they were clearly connected to a school-related activity. Wyatt knew this activity was happening and allowed it to continue for years, despite knowing the lack of supervision created the possibility for students to be hurt. They were lucky this was the first time they had an injury.

■ **JOE LUCAS, principal**

“We have to have policies in place to prevent hazing or anything even a little close to hazing. Texas Education Code says you have committed an offense if you engage in hazing, attempt hazing or even if you know about the hazing and do not report it. This is why we have some of the disciplinary actions in place. Furthermore, any action that causes bodily harm to another is a misdemeanor. The code even says that if parents or the students themselves give permission, the action is still hazing. This is all spelled out in the education code in addition to the student code of conduct.

“School traditions should be positive. Just because something is a tradition does not make it OK. When people get hurt during school activities, the school is obligated to take action. That’s what happened here.”

■ **MALLORY O’BRIEN, junior**

“I’m in a tremendous amount of pain all the time. I can’t even turn my body to do anything. It hurts to sit, stand, walk, ride in a car and sit in my desk. Everything. I’m sorry for the trouble this is causing for the team. Dance is something I’ve been passionate about my whole life. I knew they had some activity planned where I would be kidnapped in my sleep. I had always heard they did that. I had no idea when or what they would do. When I saw they were loading us all into a big SUV, I said ‘No way,’ but one of them said I’d lose my position if I didn’t get in. I don’t know if that was true, but I thought I’d better comply. I wish I hadn’t.”

■ **SELENA PEÑA, senior**

“This is the silliest punishment I have ever seen the school give in my time here. The captains and lieutenants do this every year. They literally pick up the new leaders and take them to the local church parking lot. They make them read an oath of loyalty to the program and do trust falls and silly games. My sister had to do it when she was a captain. I wanted to do it too, but I didn’t make the cut last year. The saddest part of all this is that I’m losing my dance teacher and my last spring dance concert of my senior year all because of a car accident. I’m sorry Mallory was hurt, but now, because she’s suing the school, it’s not just her who has to suffer. This has ruined our whole team.”

■ **FATIMA KHAN, senior**

“Ms. Wyatt has been my teacher for four years. She’s an incredible coach and mentor. She has led our team to multiple national championships. It’s unbelievable that she will likely lose her job because of something she wasn’t even involved in. I also can’t believe all our captains are gone for 45 days. I’ve been leading our workouts and rehearsals as best I can. But I didn’t sign up for a leadership position, and I didn’t sign up to be on the dance team without a dance instructor. I know what the leaders do when they do the initiation ceremony. It is not hazing. They aren’t forced to participate, and they don’t do anything to cause harm. This is all a real shame.”

DO NOT PASS OUT TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST

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Editorial Writing Contest Tips and Sample Stories

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Lead with a statement of the situation and then take a clear, definitive staff stance. The situation is whether or not the district will reverse its disciplinary decision for dance team members and their instructor.
2. As a general rule, use third person. If you must use a pronoun, use first person plural (we, meaning "we, the newspaper staff"). Do not use first person singular (I, me, mine) or second person (you). Avoid unnecessary use of pronouns. Rather than "We believe the district should..." write instead, "The district should..."
3. Don't waddle into the editorial. Get right to the point and, as a general rule, don't ask questions. An editorial should answer questions, not ask them. Above all, remember that your purpose is to make thoughtful, logical arguments in support of your position, not to engage in a tirade. The editorial should not be long — 450 words at the most. Although it's not recommended all the time, sometimes a writer could use a feature opening to grab the reader's attention and draw them into the story.
4. Look for the future angle. This should be somewhere in your lead.
5. Once you've stated your position/stance, the body of the editorial should support your stance and refute the opposition.
6. After the body of your editorial, complete the editorial with a specific solution.
7. Avoid direct quotes. You can pull information from these quotes, as has been done here, but it's not necessary to attribute that information unless the person has substantial credibility.
8. Watch for factual errors. Pay attention to minor details. Also, stay focused.
9. Don't clutter up the editorial with clichés or trite phrases such as "adults don't understand teens" or any variation thereof. Also, edit out the name of the school unless it is necessary for clarity. It isn't necessary to say "Leaguetown Independent School District" or "Leaguetown High School." Students know the name of the school. They don't need to be reminded.

SAMPLE EDITORIAL/SUPPORTING THE TEAM'S APPEAL

A group of dance students hopes to have their Disciplinary Alternative Education Program placement reduced and their coach reinstated when they appeal the district's disciplinary decision to the school board March 26.

The group was sent to DAEP for 45 days, and the coach was placed on leave after the team captains picked up newly selected leaders at 2 a.m. for a traditional "initiation ceremony." Students were made to pile into an SUV. The car crashed and one student fell out, breaking her collarbone, while two other students sustained concussions. The district called the incident hazing.

The school board should listen to their appeal, release the students from DAEP and allow Coach Andrea Wyatt to return to her position.

This incident was an unfortunate accident, but it was not hazing. Parents and students were all aware of the dance team tradition. Students willingly participated. They were headed to a local church parking lot to take an oath and play a few games but simply had an accident on the way.

Having no leadership and no instructor for dance classes means the program will cancel its spring concert, which was scheduled for May 2. This unneeded disciplinary action doesn't just cause problems for the teacher and students disciplined. This is a major disappointment for the whole program. Students have been working hard all year to perform in the final show of the year.

Wyatt has won multiple national championships for dance, and her students respect her. She knew the event was happening but knew no details. Students perform this harmless ceremony every year without her involvement. She will likely lose her job for doing nothing wrong if the school board does not agree with the students' appeal.

This incident does technically fall under the category of hazing in the Texas Education Code, but the code should allow for more flexibility. And the school board has the ability to see the nuances in this particular incident.

This accident was unfortunate, but that's exactly what it was — an accident. The school board should hear this appeal and allow the dance team to go back to what they do best and prepare for another spring show.

SAMPLE EDITORIAL/OPPOSING THE TEAM'S APPEAL

A group of dance students hopes to have their Disciplinary Alternative Education Program placement reduced and their coach reinstated when they appeal the district's disciplinary decision to the school board March 26.

The group was sent to DAEP for 45 days, and the coach was placed on leave after the team captains picked up newly selected leaders at 2 a.m. for a traditional "initiation ceremony." Students were made to pile into an SUV. The car crashed and one student fell out, breaking her collarbone, while two other students sustained concussions. The district called the incident hazing.

The school board should keep the students at DAEP and the teacher off campus for the safety of all students and for the good of the program going forward.

The school can't allow hazing to go on. It can't knowingly allow anything remotely in the same ballpark as hazing to go on. Unfortunately, this incident does fall into that ballpark, according to Texas Education Code as well as the district's student code of conduct. The district must use this incident as an example to prevent other teams, groups and organizations from trying to pull off something similar.

Coach Andrea Wyatt should not get her job back. While she didn't participate, she knowingly allowed a school activity to go on off campus outside the school day where students were unsupervised. Even if this event wasn't hazing, which it was, leaving students unsupervised doing a dance team-related activity is irresponsible. The dance team is lucky no one was hurt before now.

Those who say this incident was not hazing are missing the part where a student ended up with broken bones and two other students ended up with concussions. The fact that they called the event an "initiation ceremony" and that people were hurt means this incident is clearly hazing. Wyatt had full knowledge of that.

School traditions can be nice and fun, but there are more important things than tradition — like student safety. Students can't lead the dance team if they have broken bones. Not only should the school board deny this appeal, the future leaders and future coach of the dance team should make safety their first priority and come up with a new, safer tradition.